

Law of Minimal Effort

What is it?

People choose the easiest possible option to achieve a goal. Humans naturally avoid extra work if a simpler path exists.

History

Referenced in cognitive psychology and UX research since around **1957**, highlighting that the mind always seeks the path of least resistance to conserve mental energy and effort.

The Psychology Behind It

- Brain prefers actions that require less cognitive load
- Simpler pathways feel faster and safer
- Extra steps create emotional friction
- Users abandon tasks when effort feels too high

Why It Matters

- Lower conversions
- Reduced engagement
- Higher frustration
- Lower satisfaction and trust

How to Apply It

- Remove unnecessary distractions
- Minimize waiting time and loading delays
- Use progressive disclosure for complex flows
- Provide clear, straightforward navigation

Theory in Action

- Angellist uses distinct button styling to simplify “Login” and “Join” entry points
- Self-checkout kiosks streamline payment to reduce effort in grocery stores

Final Thought

People always gravitate toward the easiest path.

Good UX removes friction — not adds it — so users feel progress, not pressure.

